

4. ONE GOD IS THE SPIRIT

Those who embrace the traditional doctrine of the Trinity believe in a literal distinction between the three “persons” of the Trinity. Often, this distinction leads to one person receiving less attention than the others. From their writings, we can discern that it is the person of the Holy Spirit which is frequently relegated to the margin. In his book with the telling title, *The Forgotten Trinity*, James R. White (1998) explains why, in his opinion, the Holy Spirit receives less attention than the Father and the Son.

There is a reason why the Holy Spirit does not receive the same kind of attention that is focused upon the Father and the Son: it is not His purpose to attract that kind of attention to himself...He does not seek to push himself into the forefront and gain attention for himself...One result of this voluntary role of the Spirit in the work of salvation is that the evidences of His

*personality and deity are not as numerous or obvious as those for the Father or the Son.*³

There are several problems with such an explanation. To begin with, it raises a number of questions relating to the so-called co-equality of the three. According to James R. White, the Holy Spirit does not like to gain attention for Himself, unlike the Father and the Son, although he doesn't state the latter, it is clearly assumed. This is evidence that Trinitarians believe in three separate "Gods", as each one seems to have a different personality – where the first two "seek attention", while the third member seems more modest and is content to allow the first two to share the limelight. White confesses that there aren't many Scriptures which clearly prove the personality of the Holy Spirit. The truth is that there are no Scriptures to support such a polytheistic

3

White, J. (1998). *The Forgotten Trinity: Recovering the heart of Christian belief*. Minnesota: Bethany House Publishers. Page 139.

conception of the Godhead. To gain a biblical understanding of the identity of the Holy Spirit, we will need to start in the beginning:

Genesis 1:1 *In the beginning God created the Heaven and the earth.*

Genesis 1:2 *And the earth was without form, and void; and darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters.*

When God created the Heavens and the earth, His Spirit *moved* on the face of the waters. Earlier, we saw how the one God created all things. Genesis 1:2 shows that the Creation was set in motion when the Spirit of God moved. We can only conclude that the Spirit of God is His very own essence. In order to create *ex nihilo* (out of nothing), renew, refresh, and sustain, among others, the Spirit of God – i.e. He, Himself – must move and act.

Psalms 104:30 *Thou sendest forth thy spirit, they are created: and thou renewest the face of the earth.*

Another way to comprehend this is to ask the following question with some caution: what is God? The answer is Spirit, as Jesus, Himself, teaches us.

John 4:24 *God is a Spirit: and they that worship him must worship him in spirit and in truth.*

In John 4:24, Jesus makes no distinction between God and the Spirit. When one prays in the Spirit, one is praying to God. To envision God is to envision a spiritual being; to approach Him is to seek communication with Him through His Spirit. God and His Spirit are one and the same. The titles God the Father, and the Holy Spirit highlight different functions of the same God, but refer to the same being. That the father and the Holy Spirit, are the same, can easily be verified in the Scriptures if we ask the question: who begat the son? Have a look at the two verses below:

Matthew 1:20 *But while he thought on these things, behold, the angel of the Lord appeared unto him in a dream, saying, Joseph, thou son of David, fear not to take unto thee Mary thy wife: for that which is conceived in her is of the Holy Ghost.*

John 3:16 *For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life.*

On the surface, the two verses seem to contradict each other: Mathew 1:20 states that the Holy Spirit gave birth to the Son, while John 3:16 claims God gave birth to the Son. This is not a problem for one God adherents: God the Father is identical with the Holy Spirit. The two titles are often used interchangeably in the Bible. Take the two verses that follow as cases in point:

Act 5:3 *But Peter said, Ananias, why hath Satan filled thine heart to lie to the Holy Ghost, and to keep back part of the price of the land?*

Act 5:4 *Whiles it remained, was it not thine own? and after it was sold, was it not in thine own power? why hast thou conceived this thing in thine heart? thou hast not lied unto men, but unto God.*

Peter accused Ananias of lying to the Holy Ghost in verse 3, only to declare that he had lied to God in verse 4. It would not make any sense

whatsoever to maintain that the Holy Spirit does not seek to gain attention for Himself; if the Holy Spirit is God, which He is, then He must be glorified and magnified as such. After all, it is a command to do so:

Matthew 4:10 *Then saith Jesus unto him, Get thee hence, Satan: for it is written, Thou shalt worship the Lord thy God, and him only shalt thou serve.*

This booklet affirms the cornerstone teaching that the God of the Bible is indivisibly one, and to believe this is a matter of salvation. With reference to the identity of the Holy Spirit, a good place to begin is the Scripture, below:

Ephesians 4:4 *There is one body, and one Spirit, even as ye are called in one hope of your calling;*

Now, most Christians will readily concede that there, indeed, is but one Spirit. The bone of contention, however, is whether this one Spirit is the same Spirit that dwelt in, and was the life, of the Son of God (John 6:57). In this matter, one God Christians part ways with Trinitarians. The latter believe that the Holy Spirit is not the Son

(remember the figure?). The Scriptures are not silent on this issue. Speaking about the veil which Christ shall take away, the Apostle Paul identifies Jesus as the Spirit of God.

2 Cor 3:14 *But their minds were blinded: for until this day remaineth the same veil untaken away in the reading of the old testament; which veil is done away in Christ.*

2 Cor 3:15 *But even unto this day, when Moses is read, the veil is upon their heart*

2 Cor 3:16 *Nevertheless when it shall turn to the Lord, the veil shall be taken away*

2 Cor 3:17 *Now the Lord is that Spirit: and where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is liberty.*

Only God can fill us with His Holy Spirit. Only He can pour out of His essence into whosoever He chooses. After all, receiving the Holy Spirit is no different from God dwelling in us – Immanuel. In the Old Testament, the prophets of old frequently prophesied that God desired to pour out His Spirit upon all flesh.

Joel 2:28 *And it shall come to pass afterward, that I will pour out my spirit upon all flesh; and your sons and your daughters shall prophesy, your*

*old men shall dream dreams, your young men
shall see visions:*

Again, note the “I” of God. By this, we are to understand that it is His undertaking; His sovereign act alone. Remarkably, when the time for the fulfillment of this prophecy came, we are told in plain language that Jesus is the one who sent the Holy Ghost.

Matthew 3:11 *I indeed baptize you with water unto repentance: but he that cometh after me is mightier than I, whose shoes I am not worthy to bear: he shall baptize you with the Holy Ghost, and with fire:*

Luke 24:49 *And, behold, I send the promise of my Father upon you: but tarry ye in the city of Jerusalem, until ye be endued with power from on high.*

We are compelled to conclude that the one God speaking in Joel 2:28, and the Lord Jesus Christ, are one and the same. We are not to understand the “sending of the Holy Ghost” as if the Father sends the third member of a Trinity to fill believers. I fail to see how Trinitarians can hold such a position. How can one God “send”

another God? The biblical account agrees with the understanding that one God, who is now manifested in the flesh, sends His own essence – His Spirit – to fill believers. This is why we receive the “Spirit of Christ.”

Romans 8:9 *But ye are not in the flesh, but in the Spirit, if so be that the Spirit of God dwell in you. Now if any man have not the Spirit of Christ, he is none of his.*

Our objective is not to poke fun at those who envision three persons in the Godhead. This booklet, hopefully, will serve to challenge the taken-for-granted understanding of this very important doctrine of God. Apollos is described as “an eloquent man, and mighty in the Scriptures (Acts 18:24), but he was humble enough to be instructed by Aquila and Priscilla. I am convinced that the Lord is seeking out many Trinitarians to give them this wonderful and saving doctrine of the one God manifested in flesh, which the Apostles preached. I have found the verse, below, to be a powerful argument showing that the Spirit of Jesus Christ is the Holy Spirit.

Galatians 4:6 *And because ye are sons, God hath sent forth the Spirit of his Son into your hearts, crying, Abba, Father.*

Many believe that they have received “another” Spirit, and not that of the Son of God, Jesus Christ. They believe this because they have misunderstood the words of Jesus:

John 14:16 *And I will pray the Father, and he shall give you another Comforter, that he may abide with you for ever;*

If they would only read the next verse, it would be abundantly clear that Jesus was speaking of the Spirit in Him, and not about a different, distinct third member of the Trinity. In fact, this is conclusively settled by verses 17 and 18.

John 14:17 *Even the Spirit of truth; whom the world cannot receive, because it seeth him not, neither knoweth him: but ye know him; for he dwelleth with you, and shall be in you.*

John 14:18 *I will not leave you comfortless: I will come to you.*

Who did the Apostles know except Jesus? Who was dwelling with the Apostles all this time, if not the Lord, Himself? Thankfully, the Lord put an end to any speculation by declaring, “I will not leave you comfortless: I will come to you.” Could He have been any clearer? It is vital to appreciate that the Lord was eager to baptize them all with the Holy Spirit because, as long as He was with them in the flesh, they would be limited. As creatures that are sight-oriented, they would have remained passive, and deferred to the Lord at every instance. The spiritual principles of the Kingdom, however, operate on the basis of faith, and not sight.

John 20:29 *Jesus saith unto him, Thomas, because thou hast seen me, thou hast believed: blessed are they that have not seen, and yet have believed.*

It was necessary for the Lord to depart in flesh because it is the Spirit – His true essence – which is spatially limitless or omnipresent. Believers in any corner of the world can now assemble and experience the Spirit of the Lord Jesus Christ

fellowshipping and ministering to them. This is what the Lord meant when He stated:

Matthew 18:20 *For where two or three are gathered together in my name, there am I in the midst of them.*

How did the early Christians perceive the status or identity of the Holy Spirit? When they prayed, how did they perceive the dynamics and blessings which came through the Spirit? Several Scriptures demonstrate that they believed they were receiving impartation from the Spirit of Jesus Christ, Himself, and not the Spirit as a distinct member.

Philippians 1:19 *For I know that this shall turn to my salvation through your prayer, and the supply of the Spirit of Jesus Christ,*

In all seriousness, it is patently absurd to believe that the Holy Spirit is God and, simultaneously, unwilling to “gain attention for himself,” as James R. White opines:

He [Holy Spirit] is not “up front” and is not spoken of as often as the other persons. Some take this as evidence of inferiority, but as we have noted before, difference in function does not

indicate inferiority of nature (White, 1998, p. 139).

All this effort at elevating the status of the Holy Spirit would have been unnecessary if White understood the one God doctrine. Those who deny the words of the *Shema Israel*, found in Deuteronomy 6:4, seem condemned to labor in vain with bizarre speculations to convince us and themselves that God is not one. Significantly, when Jesus declared the commandment in Deuteronomy 6:4 to be the first and most important one, the Jewish scribe declared this God to be *he* (singular):

Mark 12:32 *And the scribe said unto him, Well, Master, thou hast said the truth: for there is one God; and there is none other but he:*

In the final chapter, we will consider Scriptures that prove one God, alone, shall return. Furthermore, this same one God – Jesus Christ – will reign on the one throne in Heaven.